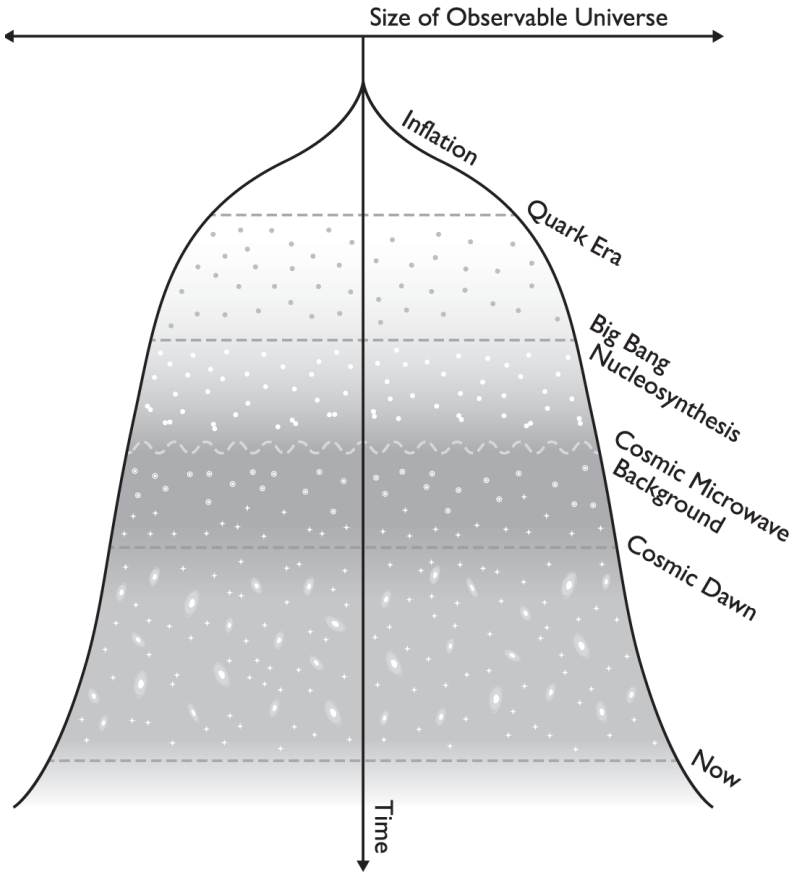


Figure 6: Cosmic timeline. The size of the observable universe increased rapidly during inflation, just after the very beginning. The universe has been expanding (at a slower rate) ever since. Labeled here are some of the important moments in the history of the cosmos.

When inflation ended, the super-stretched-out baby universe was left much colder and emptier than when it began. A process called “reheating” brought it back up to a high temperature everywhere, at which point the ordinary march of steady expansion and cooling carried on.

THE QUARK ERA

While the pre-inflation cosmos was likely ruled by a Grand Unified Theory, the post-inflation cosmos was moving closer to the laws of physics we see today. There was still a way to go, though. At this point, while the strong nuclear force had broken away from the GUT all-in-one particle physics party, electromagnetism and the weak nuclear force had not yet distinguished themselves; they were still somehow merged together as a